

The case for Groundwork

What three markets actually built, what the client has asked for in its own words, what a further market inherits, and what is deliberately not being claimed.

THE CASE IN ONE PARAGRAPH

Butterfly did not produce three markets of findings. It produced a working, checked way of turning a field week into an evidence base a client can rely on, and it ran that way three times: 30 recorded conversations across three markets, 390 rows on the Claims Register with a verdict and a source on each, a citation rule that traces a figure on a slide to the tape or the document it came from, a clearance rule for what can be said to whom, 23 checks that stop a send and run in one command, and a close-out that will not let a market finish until what it taught is written down. It is about to be asked to run in further markets, and the client's own project board cannot see any of it.

WHAT WAS BUILT

The method described as what happens to a recording, rather than as a philosophy.

Intake

A recording is dropped in a folder. It is transcribed, the speakers are named against stored voiceprints, a page is built so a person can check the naming by ear, and the file is filed under one name that carries its market, its language and its consent status.

Claims

Every factual claim in the conversation goes onto the Claims Register with who said it, where, what it rests on, and a verdict, which is supported, contested, or held until a source arrives. A held figure never reaches a page the client sees.

Citation

A figure carries its source with it. When a conversation happened in Finnish, the page that quotes it says how it became English. That note is derived from the tape itself, so a fourth market inherits it without anyone remembering to add it.

Clearance

What a surface may say depends on who reads it. The same fact can be internal, partner-safe or client-safe, and a generator refuses to write a page whose reader is not cleared for what is on it.

The checks

There are 23 checks that stop a send, alongside 61 smaller checks in the code, run by one command and reported as one verdict. They refuse a rate, a contested figure stated as fact, a retired name, an unsourced number, a status that disagrees with the artifact that settles it, and a count typed into a sentence.

Close-out

A market cannot close until what it taught has been logged and classed for the next one. The log is enforced rather than encouraged, because the checks fail a market that tries to finish without it.

WHAT BECAME PROVABLE THIS WEEK

Each of these was measured on 8 September, and each will be re-measured before it is repeated.

The checks can be passed

The full run ended green with nothing carried over, from a red that had stood for a fortnight, and every fix was made at the source. A method whose own check is permanently red is a checklist people ship past; this one is a check.

A market's vocabulary is derived

The nine deliverable names, the translation note and the citation rules are read from one place. A new market has them on the day it is created, and a retired name cannot reach a page because the build fails when one does.

A status comes from the artifact that settles it

Eight settled items were reading open on the surface everyone looks at, five because a column was kept by hand and three because a later layer overwrote a source edit. The mechanism is fixed where it broke, and a check now fails the contradiction, so the sentence has a proof behind it.

A check is tested against near-misses

Six checks in two days were wrong the same way in first draft: each matched a pattern and was never asked whether it could tell its target from something that merely looked like it. Every one now has a test case that would have caught it, which is the difference between a checklist and a check, and it is what a second operator inherits.

The estate can be measured by anyone

One command answers what is in the build and whether anyone uses it. Thirty-eight decks that had never been sent came out of the build on the same day the verdict went green, and smaller and greener at once is the argument for the method rather than for the effort.

The counting is honest, and the number went down

An earlier index called every long turn in the transcripts a quotation. The method now counts only the turns tied to a commitment, and says how sure it is of each one. A smaller number with a confidence on it is worth more than a larger one without.

WHAT THE CLIENT ASKED FOR, IN THEIR OWN WORDS

From the working notes at the tail of their own interview-questions document, with the structure kept and nothing tidied.

The formats

They list local photography for mailers and out-of-home, stories for their own paid media, stories to gather at existing sites and at net-new communities, physical leave-behinds, one-page static

testimonials, videos in flagship and social cuts, decks, in-person event engagements including town halls, and community-to-community dialogue, meaning how to support a community in the conversation, for community leaders getting questions and for chambers of commerce.

The substance

They want a place that has evolved and grown but retained its character, and they ask what a new community needs to know from a community that has a longstanding data center. They name retail, a way of life that is consistent, intergenerational families, businesses that are doing well, hard numbers and economic impact, and construction set against ongoing employment.

Read the substance list again, because it is not a content brief. Six of the eight lines are evidence propositions: that businesses are doing well, that there are hard numbers behind the economic impact, that construction employment differs from ongoing employment, that the way of life is consistent. Each is either supported in a specific market by a specific source, or it is not. They have written a research brief and filed it under content.

The single most consequential line is the one about what a new community needs to know from a community that has a longstanding data center. That is the whole product, a long-tenure market answering a new one. Community-to-community dialogue is the same thing again, and it is the format to build toward: not a film about a town, but a structured way for a town that has one to answer a town that is getting one. An agency cannot supply that, because it requires the older market's evidence base, and that is what exists here.

WHERE THE EVIDENCE ALREADY REACHES

Roughly half of the list sent on 3 September already sits inside research that has been done. Loudoun County is on the list and is already the comparable in this evidence base, on the county's own figure that data centers supply 38 percent of its general fund. The per-household offset that travels with that figure is modeled by an advocacy body and is attributed separately for that reason. Muskogee County and Stillwater sit in the same regulatory and ratepayer environment as Pryor, where the relevant state law and the ballot history are already worked.

None of that is a coincidence. It is the answer to why this partnership rather than an agency, and it is an argument about what a further market inherits: the register, the checks, the citation rules and the source library. It is currently written down in one file inside the delivery project, where the expansion planning cannot see it.

THE FAILURE MODE ONLY THIS FIXES

On 4 September the client's project board and the evidence base were compared line by line for the first time, and of the thirty-seven comparable lines, three were clean. The board tracks outputs, which film, which profile, which deck, and it cannot see the transcripts, the cleared quotations, the adjudicated claims or the source library that produced them.

That is not carelessness on anyone's part. It is what happens when an evidence method has no representation in the layer where decisions are taken. At three markets it costs a reconciliation

session. At the scale now being discussed it is unmanageable, and it is precisely the thing a further market pays for: not fieldwork, but the layer that keeps the client's own board honest about what the fieldwork found.

WHAT IS DELIBERATELY NOT CLAIMED

The discipline the whole thing rests on. A claim on this page that could not survive a check would be the drift the method exists to prevent.

Not that the product is built

The part that travels is measured and ordered. The shared modules that block the most generators have been moved into a template that rebuilds on its own, and the rest are queued with their blockers named. A fourth market standing up from the template without reading a file from the pilot is the acceptance test, and it has not been passed yet.

Not a market count

Three numbers are in circulation for the expansion and they are not interchangeable. None goes on a surface until Dave says which list is the list, because a number chosen for him is exactly the drift the method exists to prevent.

Not a rate, anywhere

Every commercial figure lives in one private place. A planning surface carries a pointer and never the figure.

Not a contested figure as fact

Every figure that has been argued over has a say-safe wording and a do-not-say. This document uses only figures that are cleared, and only in the wording they are cleared in.

Not that the method is safe to hand over yet

As of this week the part that travels lives in one folder with a local history and no remote. Where it lives decides who can see it, which is a commercial decision rather than a housekeeping one, and it has not been taken. Saying we can hand you the method and leaving that unsaid would be the kind of gap the method exists to close.

WHAT IT IS WORTH

Worth here is measured in what a fourth market inherits on the day it opens, because that is the only number a buyer can check. It inherits the shape of a market, four moves in ten phases, each phase with an owner, an instrument and a gate, and a budget that prices those same phases. It inherits the register and its verdict vocabulary, the listening lens, the interview instrument, the citation and clearance rules, the checks that stop a send, and the close-out that will not let a market finish until what it taught is written down. It inherits the learnings of the markets before it, classed as universal, conditional or local, so the fourth market starts where the third finished rather than where the first did. And it inherits the people trained against the method, which is the part that cannot be handed over as a document.

Who owns which part of that is now described rather than assumed. The practice has written down its background intellectual property, what it brought in, what it built alongside the engagement for the method, and what it does not claim, which is every deliverable, every recording, every register row and every film, and the description of the method that the final phase of the statement of work hands the client. That document is with Dave. It proposes nothing; it exists so that the next conversation can be about terms rather than about definitions, and terms are that next conversation, not this page.

WHERE THIS LEAVES THE CONVERSATION

Two things are needed from Dave and nothing else is asked: which list is the list, and an hour with the board open, because the argument on this page is easier to see than to read.

Internal to the partnership. Every apparatus figure in this document was measured at build time; every dated count carries its date.